

词汇: *confidence* 自信

- 1 Do you know anyone who is more confident in their own abilities than their actual **performance** suggests they should be? Perhaps they think they are an incredible singer, but they're actually **tone-deaf**. Most people believe that they are more intelligent and skilful than the average person, according to a 2020 meta-analysis by Zell and colleagues. Obviously, this cannot be the case. Overconfidence has a cost – it can lead to things like poor financial decisions and dangerous driving. So why do we have such a **tendency** to **overestimate** our abilities?
- 2 Excessive **self-belief** requires **self-deception** – believing your own **falsehoods**. An evolutionary perspective argues that humans evolved self-deception so that we could **deceive** others more easily. The theory goes that if you believe your own lies about your abilities, you're less likely to display behaviours which will **give it away**, such as nervousness or **hesitation**. Deceiving others about your abilities may enable you to open doors, but it is when you have to **prove yourself** that overconfidence can lead to costly mistakes. For those who have a greater **underlying** ability, though, overconfidence can be highly beneficial.
- 3 This is what researchers are calling the '**peacock's** tail for people'. Peacocks have long and brightly coloured feathers to attract females, but they are extremely **burdensome**. The feathers are heavy and highly visible to predators, so only the healthiest peacocks can afford to carry such **elaborate plumage**. In other words, their feathers are a reliable indicator of their suitability for potential mates. Authors of a 2026 study, published in the Psychological Review compare this **phenomenon** with human overconfidence. They argue that only the most capable people can keep a high self-belief without suffering severe consequences. In other words, overconfidence may actually be a useful signal of ability.
- 4 So, what lessons can be learnt from all this? If you have a high ability in a particular skill, make sure you have the confidence to match it. Ability can bring success, but remember, it is confidence which opens the doors in the first place.

测验与练习

一、将标题和段落配对。

Paragraph 1 _____

Paragraph 2 _____

Paragraph 3 _____

Paragraph 4 _____

Paragraph 5 _____

- a. The advice
- b. Confident humans are like healthy peacocks
- c. Overconfidence is part of human evolution
- d. Teenagers tend to have a lack of confidence
- e. The costs of overconfidence

二、根据文章内容选出正确的选项。

1. Most people are overconfident.
 - a. True
 - b. False
 - c. Not given
2. Overconfidence is always a good thing.
 - a. True
 - b. False
 - c. Not given
3. When you believe your own lies about your abilities, you are more likely to...
 - a. deceive others effectively.
 - b. be nervous or hesitate.
 - c. make costly mistakes.
4. Authors of the 2026 study compare peacock feathers to...
 - a. human health.
 - b. human ability.
 - c. human overconfidence.
5. The article writer argues that overconfidence is...
 - a. mostly positive.
 - b. mostly negative.
 - c. neither positive nor negative.

三、用方框中的单词完成对本文的总结。

Humans have a **1)** _____ to be overconfident, believing their **2)** _____ is better than it actually is. Confidence may make it easier to **3)** _____ people about your abilities, but once you've opened the doors, you then have to **4)** _____, and if your abilities don't match up, negative consequences can follow. But success can come when high **5)** _____ is balanced with a high level of ability.

self-belief	performance	phenomenon
deceive		tendency
burdensome		prove yourself

(答案见词汇表后)

词汇表

performance	表现
tone-deaf	五音不全的
tendency	倾向, 趋势
overestimate	高估
self-belief	自信, 自我信念
self-deception	自我欺骗
falsehood	谎言, 虚假陈述
deceive	欺骗
give (something) away	泄漏, 暴露 (某事)
hesitation	犹豫
prove oneself	证明自己
underlying	潜在的, 根本的, 深层的
peacock	孔雀
burdensome	沉重的
elaborate	华丽繁复的
plumage	全身羽毛, 羽衣
phenomenon	现象

答案

一、将标题和段落配对。

Paragraph 1 **e) The costs of overconfidence**

Paragraph 2 **c) Overconfidence is part of human evolution**

Paragraph 3 **b) Confident humans are like healthy peacocks**

Paragraph 4 **a) The advice**

二、根据文章内容选出正确的选项。

1. **a. True. *Most people believe that they are more intelligent and skilful than the average person, according to a 2020 meta-analysis by Zell and colleagues.***
2. **b. False. *Overconfidence has a cost – it can lead to things like poor financial decisions and dangerous driving.***
3. **a. *An evolutionary perspective argues that humans evolved self-deception so that we could deceive others more easily.***
4. **c. *Authors of a 2026 study, published in the Psychological Review compare this phenomenon [the display of peacock feathers] with human overconfidence.***
5. **a. While overconfidence can be costly, it is largely positive due to its ability to open doors for people and be a useful signal of ability for those observing.**

三、用方框中的单词完成对本文的总结。

Humans have a **tendency** to be overconfident, believing their **performance** is better than it actually is. Confidence may make it easier to **deceive** people about your abilities, but once you've opened the doors, you then have to **prove yourself**, and if your abilities don't match up, negative consequences can follow. But success can come when high **self-belief** is balanced with a high level of ability.